

Contemporary Art and Spectacle

The end of cultural history manifests itself on two opposite sides: the project of its supercession in total history, and the organization of its preservation as a dead object in spectacular contemplation. One of these movements has linked its fate to social critique, the other to the defense of class power.

— Guy Debord, *Society of the Spectacle*

It is no secret that our culture is fascinated by images of fascism (in film Rainer Fassbinder, Hans Jürgen Syberberg...and in art Robert Longo, Jack Goldstein, Troy Brauntuch, Anselm Kiefer, Gilbert & George...), and this fascination cannot be explained away either as a dandyish taste for the scandalous or as a return, not of the repressed, but of the desire for repression. For any such hypothesis there is no end of evidence (one sees a new authoritarianism as well as a new irrationalism everywhere). But I want to think about “fascinating fascism” in other terms—in terms of the *irreality* of contemporary capitalist culture.

Recently, Jean Baudrillard has suggested one reason why fascism is the site of such attraction. We suffer, he says, from a “loss of the real,” and in order to compensate we have made a fetish of the period prior to this loss—the period of fascism (especially World War II).¹ For Freud the fetish is a substitute which blocks or displaces a traumatic discovery of loss (i.e., castration); it is often the last thing experienced before the event. Thus, if the trauma of

postwar consumer society is the loss of the real, fascism might well be our fetish period.

Now on the face of it this idea seems absurd. Fascism as a period with a purchase on the real? It is infamous instead for its irrationality. But this paradox is precisely why it fascinates us, for it is in fascism that one sees a culture struggle with the loss of the real. How else to explain (on the cultural level at least) the fanatical resurrection in fascism of atavistic representations — myths of nature, race, empire, of blood and soil — except as a desperate means, in the face of the one-dimensionality of modern life, to rescue a sense of the real? Clearly, Nazi leadership exploited this cultural trauma, and just as clearly they exploited the modern mediums and effects which did so much to dissolve the real — mediums like film, effects like spectacle.² This is one reason why contemporary artists have explored representations of fascism: because in them one sees both an extraordinary investment in the real and an extraordinary manipulation of its loss (in spectacular pageants and films).

It is a commonplace to say that the primary public representation in the 20th century is now film or television, not architecture or sculpture (though the very term is suspect, if one grants the loss of the real). Of course, the Third Reich invested in old forms like architecture (the rigid classicist vocabulary of fascist monuments makes clear the pretensions of this "Empire of 1000 Years") even as it explored new forms, like film, of spectacular control. In fact, one can point to a specific instance in which the ideological stress passes from architecture to film — in the 1935 Leni Riefenstahl "documentary" of the Nazi rally at Nuremberg. There architecture becomes purely scenographic: Albert Speer designed the stadium essentially as a set for a cinematic event. (Note in general his obsession with the "ruin-effect" of architecture, a spectacle planned for posterity.) In this example we glimpse how the spectacle works as a simulated reality, a total illusion, a set of effects that consumes the primary event.

In the work of an artist like Robert Longo we are once again in a world of spectacle — but, more, we are in a "world of simulation, ...of the murder of every symbolic form and its hysterical, histor-

ical retrospection."³ For Longo traces not only our loss of the real but also our morbid attempt to compensate for this loss via the resurrection of archaic images and forms. To think about Longo in these terms, one should turn to his performances, in particular *Empire*. Comprised of three pieces – "Sound Distance of a Good Man" (1977), "Surrender" (1979) and "Empire" (1981), with a fourth, "Iron Voices" (1982), added later – the performance deploys dance, music, sculpture, film and expressionistic theater to spectacular effect.⁴ "Sound Distance" and "Surrender" are both sculptural/cinematic triptychs. Each consists of three simultaneous tableaux, arrayed horizontally and spectrally before the audience, that simulate different art forms. "Sound Distance," for example, simulates sculpture, dance, film and voice but in such a way that each is stripped of its conventional supports (e.g., narrative) and known only in its effects (pose, lighting, etc.). Thus is enacted a simultaneous estrangement- and fascination-effect, which enables one to see how these "spectacular" arts operate.

"Sound Distance" corroborates this note of Guy Debord: "The spectacle in general, as the concrete inversion of life, is the autonomous movement of the nonliving."⁵ Each art form is represented in terms of an opposition of "live" elements (present, active, etc.) versus "dead" ones (represented, prerecorded, etc.). In the tableau to the left, two spotlighted wrestlers slowly revolve on a pedestal in a way which conflates dance and sculpture and opposes the live fact to the aesthetic form of two bodies. The center tableau is a screen on which is projected a *motion* picture of a *still* photograph. Again, an ambiguity of live versus dead, which in turn is echoed by the photograph – of a man, back arched as if just shot, in front of a massively immobile statue of a lion. Finally, in the tableau to the right, a soprano sings in an operatic forte at first with but then against a prerecorded tape of music and voices.

Here, as in the other tableaux, oppositions are posed, blurred, broken down: simulations are let loose, and the order of things – what is present, what is represented – is confused. "Sound Distance" does not reduce each form to a modernist essence; rather, it strips each to surfaces, to effects without origin or referent. (For

example, the film is of a photo of a man posing "as" a Longo relief that was in turn derived from a newspaper image of a fragment of a still from a Fassbinder film. . . . Sheer text: a production of images without truth content, an effect of immediacy through mediation.) These simulations seduce us in the manner of commodities. "Where the dream is at its most exalted," Adorno wrote of Wagner, "the commodity is closest to hand. . . . The object that [the subject] has forgotten he has made is dangled magically before his eyes, as if it were an absolutely objective manifestation."⁶ In the commodity and spectacle all traces of productive labor and material support are erased; they fascinate us because they exclude us, place us in the passive position of the dreamer, spectator, *consumer*. In the Longo spectacle, we are made aware of this magical manipulation in the very act of consumption.

"Surrender" is also a triptych comprised of two long black runways on either side with three spotlights each and a movie screen in the center. A saxophonist plays and walks jerkily from the right, a film image of a Greek statue fades in and two dancers are revealed on the left. Very slowly — as images — the dancers and saxophonist move down the runways; as they do so, the music changes (from rhythmic to romantic to shrill) as do the styles of the dancers: in effect, they rehearse a short history of postwar popular dance. All this happens under the ægis of a motionless film of the Greek athlete, an image of conflicted investment (humanist nostalgia, authoritarian power). In "Surrender" we are again presented with seductive simulations, in this case, of pop forms of music and dance, dialectical counterparts to the high-art forms in "Sound Distance" and even more manipulative. The title "Surrender" catches this duality nicely: it speaks at once of romantic seduction and authoritarian subjection.

"Culture," we are warned at this point, "is not a burden, it is an opportunity. It begins with order, grows with liberty, and dies in chaos." This chaos, often a pretext for a return to order, is simulated in "Empire." A horizontal rank of spotlights appears amidst smoke and music for brass, strings and organ. The effect — the light colonnade and the fanfare music — evokes the spectacle at its most

explicit. As the rank of lights ascends, the music becomes martial, and male and female dancers in evening dress file in. Slowly the lights turn toward the audience, the music shifts to waltz and the couples dance. More dancers appear in waves as the music accelerates. Soon they are pressed against the audience in one rhythmic mass. Suddenly an air-raid siren sounds, and the performance ends in darkness with a clarion call of trumpets. Like Ravel's *La valse* (1920), "Empire" is a "frantic *danse macabre*"⁷ that signals the violent death of a certain world; yet here Ravel's *fin-de-siècle* Vienna has become *fin-de-siècle* New York—and another empire altogether."

In each piece of *Empire* elements of the arts, of popular culture, of spectacle are broken down, stilled, reframed so that we are paradoxically made aware of our own seduction. This in turn allows us to see how the spectacle functions: unlike a typical representation which works via our faith in its realism, spectacle operates via our fascination with the hyperreal, with "perfect" images that make us "whole" at the price of delusion, of submission. We become locked in its logic because spectacle both effects the loss of the real and provides us with the fetishistic images necessary to deny or assuage this loss. Our fascination with spectacle is thus even more total than it is with the commodity. If in the commodity-form "a definite social relation between men" assumes "the phantasmagoric form of a relation between things" (Marx), in spectacle it assumes a relation between *images*. (In spectacle even alienation is turned into an image for the alienated to consume; indeed, this may stand as a definition of spectacle.) This is why for Debord and others spectacle represents the very nadir of capitalist reification: with "capital accumulated to such a degree that it becomes an image" (Debord), social process becomes utterly opaque and ideological domination assured. In an earlier moment in bourgeois culture "the opacity and omnipotence of the social process [was] celebrated as a metaphysical mystery,"⁸ transformed into myth (the best example is Wagner); in our own moment it is consumed as an image. Now as Longo represents this reification, recreates our fascination, he de-creates it in part; yet even in these early works there is an ambiva-

lence, and the seduction threatens to consume the skepticism.

Clearly, Longo is fascinated by the rhetoric of public representations (monuments, statues, reliefs...); again and again he has re-framed archaic and/or authoritarian forms (though whether to draw *on* or to draw *out* the power invested there is not always clear). Why? Such forms bind a public via symbolic representation to a leader, an event, a place – to a given history and reality. That such representations vary in meaning is no surprise; they are “retooled” in time and from state to state. What is a surprise is that so many states – fascist, democratic, capitalist, communist – invest, at least officially, in the same type of representation, the same model of the historical and the real. (This investment is explored most astutely in Eisenstein’s film *October*.¹⁰ Authority – of the old regime of empire and of the old rhetoric of art – is figured there in the statue of Czar Nicholas II. With a detailed shot Eisenstein transforms this monument into an extraordinary symbol of power – which is then toppled by the revolutionary masses. In one symbolic blow the old imperial and cultural orders fall.)

Now for Longo to use old forms like the statue and archaic mediums like the relief is troublesome, but it hardly means he is celebratory of state power or *only* nostalgic for its representations. Rather, he is fascinated by the illusions at work in both discourses – fascinated by the confidence both of the state in its power (represented in the statue) and of the opposition in its truth (represented by the statue toppled). For in this regard the two sides are really of the same coin: they both invest in representation. And such investment is naïve: in our world of diffuse subjection and delirious simulation, how can one hold (whether in statist idolatry or revolutionary iconoclasm) to such models of power and truth? One answer seems evident: in the authority of these representations is concealed a fear – about a lack of authority, a loss of reality. Faced with this loss, our culture resurrects – morbidly, hysterically – archaic forms (here the statue may stand for presidential clichés about America, priestly adages about religion and family, etc.) in order to recover at least the *image* of authority or a *sense* of the real. For “it is no longer a question of a false representation



Sergei Eisenstein. *October* (still), 1927-28. (Photo courtesy Film Stills Archive, Museum of Modern Art, New York.)



Robert Longo. *Empire* (detail of "Sound Distance of a Good Man") performed at the Corcoran Gallery of Art, April 15, 1981. (Photo: Bob Epstein.)

of reality (ideology), it is a question of concealing that the real is no longer the real, and thus of saving the principal of reality."¹¹ It is this fetishism – of the real as well as of the commodity-image – that Longo explores in his simulations.

In 1983 Longo exhibited three large multipartite works of the sort with which he is now identified. *Corporate Wars: Walls of Influence* is a relief triptych with a battle royal of young business types cast in aluminum in the center and two skyscrapers in high wood relief as wings; *Love Police: Engines in Us (The Doors)* consists of two red busts set above a bronze relief of auto wreckage and flanked by two portrait panels of children on either side; and *Noweverybody (for R. W. Fassbinder)* is a four-panel drawing of a rubble-strewn street with a contorted bronze figure set out from the left panel. These three works, based like all Longo images on photographs, can be read singly or as an ensemble, a procession of public representations.

Like props for an expressive film, the two buildings in *Corporate Wars* mime the classic syndrome of modern city life: oppression and vertigo. But Longo's metropolis is not Kafka's or even Lang's: as is clear from the glossy relief surfaces, it trades in seduction and thrill, not estrangement and fear – which suggests a note of parody in *Corporate Wars*. This comes clear in the center relief: a mockery of corporate order, it is also a parody of history presented as an orderly procession of power, the ritual narrative of the state. Here the relief form is used perversely to expose what such history usually conceals – intraclass conflict. But to depict such struggle in mythic form is to render it absurd. Clearly, lived experience has eluded representation – which leads to two further thoughts: how difficult we find it today to image forth our present reality (of world banks, electronic information, etc., etc.) and how dangerous it is that we rely on archaic representations. (Can we really think of multinational affairs in terms of corporate "wars," or of nuclear superpowers in terms of 19th-century nation states?) Longo participates in this archaism deliberately – as if to rehearse the obsolescence of our thought, the inadequacy of our representations.

In any case his revival of old forms like relief and statuary is a

"bombasting" of our new-old artistic forms and public myths. Here we are very far from the modernist enterprise of "truth to materials" and "essence of the medium" – far too from the modern use of myth as order imposed on the chaos of contemporaneity (the famous T. S. Eliot dictum about *Ulysses*). Longo's is not this serious modern reference as subtle allusion, nor is his the flagrant antimodern reference, found in much contemporary art and architecture, used to resurrect old values (if Longo quotes past art at all, it is only to collide it with a contemporary form – a movie or magazine image, say). In his quotations there is no truth-value: his is a mystification so outrageous as to demystify (corporate wars as a Roman frieze?), as to provoke us to think about the uses of public representations past and present. After all, "what liberates metaphor, symbol, emblem from poetic mania, what manifests its power of subversion, is the *preposterous*."¹²

Love Police: Engines in Us (The Doors), the next station in this passion of public forms, is also a triptych of sorts: a stack of wrecked cars in bronze relief guarded by male and female busts and at the sides by four portraits. Longo refers to the bronze relief as *The Doors*, perhaps with the Rodin *Gates of Hell* and its antecedents in mind. But again a rhetorical collision of representations, not an art-historical connection, is the operation here. *The Doors* portrays a junkyard, not a Last Judgement – in precious bronze an image of scrap metal, in the medium of history a representation of commodity debris.

Above this empire of surplus and waste preside the two red busts. Cast in quasi-social-realist style at its most bombastic, these "love police" evoke the "thought police" of Orwell's 1984. ("He gazed up at the enormous face. . . . But it was all right, the struggle was finished. He loved Big Brother.") Yet even this thematic of complicity seems dated; even this representation of the future seems obsolete. Again we see how difficult it is to represent our social reality, how archaic our images (even of the future) have become. Meanwhile, the four portraits – on the left a white boy and an oriental girl and on the right a black boy and a white girl – comprise an image of the Family of Man, democratic perhaps but

potentially dystopian, for the Family of Man is really a benign version of the society of 1984: both operate on the suppression of difference or its reduction to stereotype. Yet here these policed figures oppose such suppression: pressed up against the frame, each child defies representation, insists on difference, refuses to be seen either as "our child" or as our other.

Noweverybody (for R. W. Fassbinder)¹³ explores most fully the contradictions of public representations today. The title suggests an apocalypse in which everyone is represented, but the image is of a public evacuated, if not destroyed; the only figure in the work is the bronze statue posed in violent contrapposto and set out into our space. Here again Longo plays with the hierarchy of representations: the historical scene (devastated Beirut) in a charcoal drawing, the anonymous man in fine bronze: with the result that we cannot quite specify what site or space this is — real, æsthetic, simulated or all three? Reality and representation, cause and effect slip and slide in a way that recalls the delirious reversals of *Gravity's Rainbow*. ("The last image was too immediate for any eye to register. It may have been a human figure, dreaming of an early evening in each great capital luminous enough to tell him he will never die, coming out to wish on the first star. But it was *not a star*, it was falling, a bright angel of death. And in the darkening and awful expanse of screen something has kept on, a film we have not learned to see. . . . Now everybody —")

The public representation in *Noweverybody* is not the traditional statue or relief but a documentary image of Beirut. Yet such is the status of public representation today — a diffuse mass mediated by *Time* and TV images. This renders the absence in this street strangely appropriate: an historical scene "without a subject." (One recalls the Straub/Huillet film *History Lessons*, a search for the lost site of history, a circling around a vacated center.) But there is another absence at work here too. This "documentary" image of Beirut is not documentary at all (Longo based the drawing on four different photos). Reality here is a construct (which makes one wonder how images are processed in, say, *The New York Times*), a reality that on the one hand never existed and on the other was "already

CONTEMPORARY ART AND SPECTACLE

written,” constructed by the code of what documentary truth looks like.

These speculations lead to the economy of such images and events today: not only how such images function in a discourse of “crisis” to reinject a sense of the real into our lives (which is why images of war are so privileged) but also how such events often seem to be produced in advance as media spectacles (whose importance is judged in terms of “effect” or “impact”). One is confronted with the spectacle of events produced so as to be *reproduced* as images and sold – of a history first scripted, then translated into pseudohistorical simulations to be consumed (a process in which Longo intervenes but also complies). This is why such images are so profuse and ephemeral: they must not slow down consumption and so relegate each new event to the used, the superficially known, the already familiar. Indeed, this often seems the function of spectacular representations: to use up events, to erase them in an oblivion of overexposure – or, as Debord writes, “to make his-



Robert Longo. *Noweverybody (for R. W. Fassbinder)*, 1982-83.

tory forgotten within culture." And this, finally, is the rhetorical intent of the Longo simulations: to reenact and so disclose the hyperreality of "a universe everywhere strangely similar to the original—where things are overtaken, duplicated by their own scenario."¹⁴

One persistent criticism of artists like Longo is that theirs is an art of sheer style concerned only with "look"—a criticism that suggests that we can somehow be free of our own culture, for ours is a culture of seduction, of thrill. Now to be seduced is to be at once lured and excluded by a false image of perfection: such is the mechanism of these Longo works. But this "cult of the glossy image" goes beyond seduction, as Fredric Jameson has noted: "The silence of affect in postmodernism is doubled with a new gratification in surfaces and accompanied by a whole new ground tone in which the pathos of high modernism has been inverted into a strange new exhilaration, the high, the *intensité*."¹⁵ This *intensité*, he implies, is symptomatic of a cultural "schizophrenia," a state that we witness chiefly as a breakdown in our sense of time with the result that the present rises before us in the ultravivid mode of fascination. But this fascination, Jameson insists, is experienced as a loss, an unreality.¹⁶

Such notions corroborate others noted above: the inadequacy of our historical representations, our inability to image the "unreal" present, the angst-ridden modern city become the delirious surround of consumer capitalism. This simulated world of commodities and spectacles all but defies representation, for representation is based on a principle of equivalence between signs and the real, whereas in simulation signs precede, posit the real. In such a world of loss and irreality, it is almost to be expected that nostalgia would consume us—a nostalgia for realist art (in an age of schizo subjectivity), a nostalgia for monuments (in an age of information), a nostalgia even for spectacle (for the spectacle implies at least some scene, some place). Longo participates in nostalgia just as he participates in fascination, but he is also able to reframe it in order to suggest how it works. Now we must be ambivalent about this enterprise—the way his hyperreal images assume the character of

commodities on display and desiccate the "desert of the real" all the more, the way Longo too may be consumed by spectacle, convinced by the very signs of power that he simulates. But he also reflects for us in these seductive works two important cultural "truths": that "simulation is the master, and nostalgia, the phantasmal, parodic rehabilitation of all lost frames of reference, is our just desserts."¹⁷

The spectacle is the guardian of sleep. — Debord

In recent years Longo's practice and position have shifted: his collision of images and materials is now even more extreme. To treat these elements "as such" is to suggest that they are historically closed, and Longo does in fact use painting as if it were a ready-made, a given sign to manipulate, not a medium of self-expression or formal innovation. Like sculpture (or any other generic form or material) it enters his work as an emblem or relic — but an emblem of its past *or* of its power? a relic of its death *or* of its resurrection? Are these empty forms tropes of the anachronism of fine art or forms for its libidinal and economic reinvestment? Do they reflect a shoring up of old class representations or the bankruptcy of such cultural guarantees? These questions lead us again to the place of art in a spectacular society.

"For the first time in world history," Walter Benjamin wrote in 1936, "mechanical reproduction emancipates the work of art from its parasitical dependence on ritual."¹⁸ To Benjamin this emancipation signaled not only the decay of the aura of art but also its potential passage from the "domain of tradition" to "another practice — politics." Fifty years later the practice which has reinscribed art is spectacle: of the two historical options posed by Benjamin, the æstheticization of politics (another connection with fascism) has overwhelmed the politicization of art. After all, what "shattered" tradition was a "sense of the universal equality of things" (i.e., the equivalence of capitalist exchange). This shattering thus represents not a "renewal of mankind" but its further alienation, of which

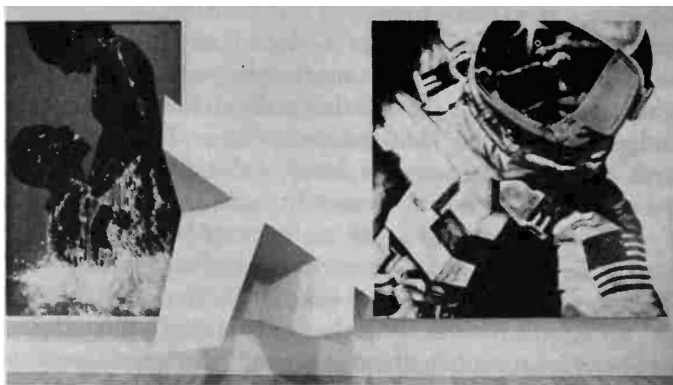
spectacle was and is a major manifestation. For in spectacle the "desire of contemporary masses to bring things 'closer' spatially and humanly" – to overcome estrangement – is falsely fulfilled precisely because what is offered is the very opposite of community, the very instrument of alienation: the commodity. (Again the double-bind of spectacle as both a symptomatic effect of reification and its supposed antidote.) In this way spectacle represents "the point at which æsthetic appearance becomes a function of the character of the commodity";¹⁹ indeed, in spectacle the lost aura of art, of tradition, of community is replaced with the "aura" of the commodity. And it is this transformation, this passage of art through the condition of spectacle, that the work of artists like Longo manifests.

Above I related Longo to the spectacular loss of the real ("the puzzlement of a class over the society it has created to the point where the historically produced reality is perceived and represented mythically");²⁰ here he must be related to the "becoming-spectacle" of art. Benjamin wrote famously of its historical passage from cult value (art as ritual instrument) to exhibition value (art precisely as work or product). Perhaps now we will have to speak of its image value, of art as a pretext for the spectacular (re)production of effects, of images, of signs – of sign exchange value. Just as the cult artifact interiorized its ritual form (its magic, its aura), so too the work, once delivered up to the marketplace after the collapse of aristocratic patronage, interiorized the commodity form; its value, separated from any (ritual) use value, became based on exhibition and exchange. Could it be that in our society of the spectacle art has begun to interiorize *its* logic, to be based not simply on exchange value but on *sign* exchange value? The work of artists like Longo is permeated by this logic, by the primacy of the image as a form of capital. Not only is its form dominated by processes of image reproduction, but so is its content – these processes are often foregrounded as themes.²¹ More important, the structures of identification typical of spectacle – scopic, voyeuristic, patriarchal – inform this art thoroughly.²²

But these remarks do not answer the initial question: does Longo

collide and invert artistic forms and spectacular images in order to question the conviction-power of the former and to sap the fascination-effect of the latter or to restore the one and exploit the other? No one for whom "the artist is the guardian of culture"²³ can be entirely critical of the ideological character of such forms and images. Yet Longo does seek to dereify cultural representations,²⁴ only he does not decode or demystify them (in the accepted way of ideological critique) so much as he *remythifies* them. In the manner of Syberberg (the German director of such film-spectacles as *Ludwig*, *Requiem for a Virgin King*, 1972, *Karl May*, 1974, *Our Hitler*, 1977, and *Parsifal*, 1982) Longo rummages through kitsch images in order to reclaim them as art and "disremembers history in order to rescue it"²⁵ as hope. This process needs to be unfolded; but first note the relation here to both academic forms and media images. Contemporary artists like Longo do not automatically disdain these things as did the moderns; they embrace them but not solely in the interests of camp or the culture industry. Often they use academic forms and media images in part because this is how history comes to us today – in the form of such myth. As Barthes wrote: "I am only the imaginary contemporary of my own present: contemporary of its languages, its utopias, its systems (i.e., of its fictions). . . but not of its history, of which I inhabit only the shimmering reflection: the *phantasmagoria*."²⁶

This then is the first step: to see in the phantasmagoria of archaic art forms and contemporary media images the figure of history, however kitsched up. The second step follows: to hold up these forms and images for our contemplation, which is at once fascinated and melancholy. The third step is to invert this "dream-kitsch" (as if literally to indicate the inverted truth that it ideologically expresses), to collide it and so to dereify it. Thus in his tableaux Longo juxtaposes incongruous things (e.g., the black couple in the water and the astronaut on a spacewalk in *Rock for Light*, the baby and the soldiers in *We Want God*) not in order to blow them apart or to disprove one image with the other or even to disenchant us: "the point is not to allow one of the poles of the image to settle into the truth of the other which it unmasks. . . , but



Robert Longo. *Rock for Light*, 1983.



Robert Longo. *We Want God*, 1983-84.

rather to hold them apart as equal and autonomous so that energies can pass back and forth between them."²⁷ But why fragment the (false) totality of spectacle only to assemble another? Why not simply deconstruct or destroy these media myths? One reason may be that such images possess a utopian (or at least collective) force and that this force can be "rescued," rewritten in another form. Too many myth-critical artists neglect this utopian aspect of the dialectic; here it is useful to recall how Marx understood religion. It is, he wrote, the "halo" of our "vale of tears" – an illusion but one that, as "an expression of protest against real wretchedness,"²⁸ reveals a truth. One must see *through* such haloes but also *see* the truth (or at least the desire, the hope) at work in them. But one can also attempt to do more: to rid them of ideological import but retain the utopian charge.

"Utopia" is one of the most corrupted of modern ideologemes, "exposed" by the likes of Orwell and Huxley to be one with dystopia, i.e., with totalitarianism. Yet this celebrated critique (now used ideologically by neoconservatives and others) often has another target: not only Marxism (which is reduced to Stalinism) but *any* social change, *any* alternative future. Recently, Marxist critics have sought to recover the utopian as a subversive concept: they argue that any cultural text, to function ideologically, must first arouse utopian desires, which only then can be defused, controlled, "managed"; indeed, that even the most ideological of these texts (fascist spectacles, Hollywood films, corporate ads) contains some collective drive or fantasy – a utopian moment that can be potentially prised open, revalued, used.²⁹ Thus it is possible that when Longo draws on his ideological sources, he does not (merely) legitimate them, nor is he (simply) seduced by them. Rather, he fragments and collides them as ideological images in order to reinscribe them as utopian ones. In the soldiers of *We Want God*, for example, there is a figure of collectivity, however perverted, and in the face of the baby in the same work there is a figure of the future, however sentimental. In short, in the most destructive forces of present society – in spectacle (*Empire*), in war (*Noweverybody*), let alone in the most regressive forms of bourgeois culture

SIGNS AND SYMPTOMS

— there is a collective, utopian dynamic that can be appropriated. Indeed, to Longo as to Ernst Bloch, the great philosopher of hope, “all passions, nihilistic as well as constructive, embody a fundamental drive towards a transfigured future.”³⁰ Now this future is at once submerged in old social and artistic forms and emergent in new ones. And this may be why Longo collides old modes, mediums, styles, images and materials—in order to reveal, perhaps even recover, the *hope* latent in them.

There are many risks and profound problems with this practice. How can a collision of ideological representations be said to dereify them? After Godard, isn't this collision a cliché—a collage device that, far from critical or utopian, actually replicates our experience of the commodity-filled landscape? More important, a utopian principle of hope may be evoked here but no actual community is engaged. This work has no social basis (other than the dominant class whose representations are collided). Its mix of archaic and futuristic forms attests to this absence—as does its apocalypticism, which is symptomatic of the failure of the dominant culture (and its “artist guardian”) to conceive social change in terms other than catastrophe. In the absence of such a social basis utopian desire may well become a will to power—or an identification with the powers that be.



Robert Morris. *Untitled*, 1983-84.



Louise Lawler. *Sappho and Patriarch* ("Is it the work, the location or the stereotype that is the institution?"), 1984.